



U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs

Veterans Health Administration
Digital Health Office

Qualitative User Research Practice Guide

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OUTLINE

1. Introduction
2. Research Methodology and Principles
3. Research Operations
4. Qualitative Research Methods
5. Data Analysis and Synthesis
6. Best Practices

This guide outlines approaches to qualitative research, why research is critical to effective product and service delivery, and how to engage in research practices. It covers research philosophy, ethics, methods, and practical tips for planning, executing, and synthesizing findings.

Pull Quote tkktk

RESEARCH METHODS AND PRINCIPLES

Research Philosophy

The goal of qualitative research is to infuse the voices of the people we serve into our process and the products and services we create. Our research strives to see people as complete human beings acting within a broader community rather than just as isolated "users" of products and services.

We cultivate a "research mindset" that is humble, comfortable with uncertainty, and open to discovery. Research is conducted to answer real questions and provide actionable guidance to push projects forward.

Guiding Principles

- Strive to be humble, trauma-informed, and experience-led
- Let people lead the way
- View people holistically, not just as users of products/services
- Ask big questions by starting small
- Make research a shared value and respected practice
- Care for researchers with the same respect given to participants

Language Considerations

- Mirror language used by participants
- Use "people" or "human" over "user"
- Embrace people-first language
- Use participants' voices when sharing experiences

RESEARCH OPERATIONS

Ethics and Safety

- Understand and address power dynamics
- Set realistic expectations
- Obtain informed consent
- Make best use of participants' time
- Acknowledge biases
- Be trauma-informed
- Listen and empathize without offering advice
- Represent information honestly
- Keep data safe and anonymous

Researcher Safety

- Prepare for safe conversations
- Protect personal contact information
- Choose safe locations for in-person research
- Cultivate self-care practices

WHEN TO CONDUCT RESEARCH

Research is most useful when conducted at the right time to inform understanding, updates, or product direction. Consider the product lifecycle stage:

- Discovery Phase: Broad, generative research
- Prototype Phase: Refining ideas through research and design probes
- Scaling and Evaluation Phases: Continuous improvement and impact assessment

Planning Research

1. Define the research project (rationale, goals, questions)
2. Select methods
3. Prepare materials
4. Find participants and plan activities
5. Set timeline and logistics
6. Conduct research
7. Analyze, synthesize, and share findings

Incentives

It is customary to compensate participants for their time, typically with gift cards. Adjust amounts based on time commitment. At VA, this applies to research with Veterans, not employees or staff. We work with specific resources to recruit Veterans.

Conducting Research with Non-Researchers

Bring team members into the field in well-defined roles. Provide guidance, templates, and debrief opportunities.

QUALITATIVE RESEARCH METHODS

In-Depth Interviews

One-hour conversations to deeply understand experiences and perspectives.

- Use throughout the design process, especially in Discovery and Evaluation phases
- Prepare a discussion guide covering consent, rapport-building, core questions, and wrap-up
- During the interview, actively listen and probe for deeper insights
- After the interview, debrief and begin initial analysis

Other Methods (not detailed in excerpt)

- Observation/shadowing
- Journey mapping
- Service blueprinting
- Intercept testing
- Concept testing
- Usability testing
- Task analysis

DATA ANALYSIS AND SYNTHESIS

- Organize and store data securely
- Analyze and synthesize findings collaboratively
- Share results in actionable formats

This guide aims to provide a framework for conducting ethical, effective qualitative research to inform product and service design.